Session 4 - Cube Scenes

Remaining encounters for table use — 2/10 collected (Aldric, Sera). Full scene text in order. FLOATING ENCOUNTER - The Flowering / Ixa Triggers between any two scenes if Ixa engages with the letter OR if the party investigates the letter's origin. If Ixa ignores it entirely: triggers end of Scene 4 (Cormac), before Scene 5. See separate scene at end of this document.

SCENE — CUBE 2 Tomas Areth

Location: his study, upper floor of the Observatory annex | Type: The Puzzle Sight: Every surface covered — notebooks stacked, star maps unrolled across the floor, charts pinned to the walls at overlapping angles. One clear space at the desk. Amber lamp burning midmorning because the shutters are closed. Sound: His pen

scratching. The building settling. Street noise below, muffled to nothing. Smell: Ink, candle tallow, old paper, something faintly metallic from the brass instruments. Touch: Moving through the room without disturbing the stacks requires care. Air: Stale. He has not opened the window today. WANT An airtight, verified activation sequence FEAR A calculation error that dooms the participants LIE "I have the sequence under control." Physical: early forties, gaunt the way you get from forgetting meals rather than skipping them. Ink-stained past the knuckles. Eyes that fix on a problem and stay there — he does not glance around rooms, he looks at whatever he is thinking about. Voice dry and

precise. When he goes still he goes completely still, like a mechanism at rest between operations. He spots the puzzle box and goes still for a moment. "Sit down. I need to show you something before we talk about the cube." He opens the notebook and slides it across without a word. "I've checked it four times. I can't check it a fifth — I've looked at it too long. I need someone who hasn't." He hands over the star charts and a rubbing of the Ashring dais. The task: sort the eight stars by brightness, verify the cube order. DC 14 Arcana. Advantage if the party examined the dais star map earlier. Tomas assists (grants advantage) but cannot find the error himself. The correct order spells FREEWILL — first letter of each star name, brightest to dimmest. Tomas's copy has the 6th and 7th entries swapped (magnitudes 3.7 and 3.9). He stopped seeing the difference decades ago. HANDOUT — STAR CHART (TOMAS'S COPY) — SLIDE THIS TO PLAYERS

Star Name Magnitude

1 Faloris 0.4
2 Rethian 1.1
3 Evorn 1.8
4 Eldenmere 2.3
5 Whitefall 3.1
6 Lethis 3.9
7 Ildemar 3.7

8 Lundavar 4.6 GM: Rows 6 & 7 are transposed — 3.9 cannot precede 3.7. Tomas's sequence: F-R-E-E-W-L-I-L. Corrected: F-R-E-E-W-I-L-L = FREEWILL. WHEN A PLAYER NAMES THE TRANSPOSITION AND READS THE WORD ALOUD

"There. I have been staring at that for three days and my eye kept sliding past it." Very still. "FREEWILL. He left us a word, not a formula. I've been checking arithmetic for forty years. It was never arithmetic." One question before anything changes hands: "Everyone comes out alive. Freely — no one's being pushed to the stone?" Wait for the answer. He needs to hear it. "The ritual runs on people being free to refuse. Which means it can always stop again. I don't know if that makes it easier to say yes or impossible." Cube and sequence together. He does not separate them. "I'm trusting you with the mechanism. Don't use it like one." On failure: correct order found, word never discovered. Tomas gives the cube. The FREEWILL confession stays buried until Session 5. If pushed at any point: "I know what that sounds like. Come back when you can ask plainly." Alternate route — if the star chart stalls: Tomas has one more sheet. Corven's original, fifty years old. A single line at the bottom in different handwriting — added the night Corven died. Read it verbatim: "Ten were asked. Nine gave. One said no. The sun went dark because she said no. She did not refuse for herself. What did she protect? What must all ten give freely? Two words." Answer: FREE WILL — Ellan refused because she was pregnant. Her child had no voice and could not consent. She protected the free will of the child who could not yet make her own choices. Corven agreed with her. The ritual cannot complete where any participant is forced — including one not yet born. Tomas, when a player names it: "I've been looking at that sheet for forty years. I never asked who the tenth was."

SCENE — CUBE 3 Ysel Maren

Location: secluded Dawnhall courtyard, stone bench, amber sky | Type: The Overlooked WANT Complete, unforced consent across all participants FEAR That Cormac's hesitation will spread to the others LIE "I have no doubts." Physical: tall, Ashfen-dark, with the deliberate posture of someone used to being the tallest person in a room and not drawing attention to it. Voice low and unhurried — she says things once and means them. She listens without nodding, without filling the

silence. When she looks at you, she is deciding something. Cube held openly in one hand when the party arrives. Sight: Secluded courtyard, stone bench, amber sky overhead. Sound: Kitchen clatter and muffled conversation from inside. Smell: Dried garden herbs, damp moss, kitchen smoke. Touch: Chilled limestone bench. Air: Crisp courtyard breeze. She hears them coming. Doesn't turn. When she does, the cube is in her coat pocket and her hands are empty. "I've been ready for seven months. I have one question before the cube moves. Not a condition — a test. I need to know if I'm giving this to people who've been paying attention." She looks at them directly. No warmth, no hostility. Measuring. "The ritual requires ten willing participants. Corven was meticulous about consent — he built it into the mechanism. Ten people, freely chosen. But the ritual changes the city. Everyone in it. People who were never asked, never told." A pause. "Name one person who will be changed by this ritual who was never asked." Not rhetorical. Not a trick. One specific named person — anyone whose life changes without their consent. A patient in the Healing House. A merchant in the Ashfen. The child Ellan carried. Any name. One name. UNLOCK: NAME A SPECIFIC PERSON — NOT AN ABSTRACTION
"Yes. That person." A pause long enough to mean it. "Corven knew. He did it anyway. I've decided that doesn't make it wrong. But it means we owe it to them to be certain we've exhausted everything else. Have you?" She waits for an answer to that too. Does not need a perfect one. Needs a real one. Cube. "His stone remains dark. He's been spiraling at the Dawnhall for three weeks. I'll let you speak with him first."
"The citizens" or any abstraction: "That's not a person. Come back when you can name one." She turns back to the stone. Not angry. Waiting. She'll be here. If players admit they haven't thought about it: "Then think about it. I've been thinking about it for three months alone. You can take ten minutes." She sits. Genuinely willing to wait while they figure it out. Players who solved the Tomas puzzle already have the best answer: Ellan's unborn child, who could not consent and whom Ellan was protecting. If they name this, Ysel goes still for a moment before responding — she didn't know about Ellan. Let that
land. After the cube: Ysel heads toward the Dawnhall, setting up the Cormac scene. She will be watching when the party arrives.

SCENE — CUBE 4 Nin Fletch

Location: Ashring-Lowmark intersection, junction marker stone | Type: The Patience Sight: Busy midmorning junction. Two roads splitting apart. Spice vendor's cart on the corner. Nin standing motionless in the flow of people, like a stone in a river. Everyone moves around them without thinking. Sound: Market calls, cart wheels, the

crowd. Nin says nothing. Smell: Pepper and dried herbs from the spice cart, fresh bread from somewhere further down, horse from the road. Touch: The crowd presses close but doesn't touch Nin. There is something in their stillness that creates a margin. Air: Open crosswind channeled between the buildings. Colder than the side streets. WANT To break their habit of indecision FEAR The finality of committing to a dangerous ritual LIE "I haven't made up my mind." — they decided weeks ago. Physical: kenku, charcoal-feathered, slight — the kind of creature a crowd flows around without noticing. Coat slightly too large, collar up. One hand always in the left pocket. They do not speak in their own voice; they piece together phrases from things they have heard before, which makes long silences common and decisive statements nearly impossible. Standing motionless at the junction marker stone. The vendor knows their order. Finding them: Any player looking at the junction sees them. Not hiding. The spice vendor calls out "Morning. The usual?" as the party passes — slides a paper twist across without looking. Nin takes it without breaking their watch. If players ask the vendor: "Been there since before Amber Week. Thought lost. Said no. Thought waiting for someone. Said maybe." When the party approaches, Nin tilts their head at the puzzle box. Makes a sound — the exact click of a puzzle-box latch. Then looks at the party, then at the east road. They have been collecting something. They will share it if the party

stops and listens. The puzzle: two sound fragments. Nin has been eavesdropping on Reckoning patrols passing through this junction for two weeks. They cannot explain what they heard. They can play it back exactly. If players indicate they are listening, Nin demonstrates in sequence — read these aloud: Fragment 1: Boots on stone — twelve pairs, measured pace. A pause at the east approach. Then seven continue forward toward the Ashring. Five turn back. A voice, half-heard: "...hold position until..." Then silence. Fragment 2: A different voice, clipped and official. Nin's mimicry is unsettling in its precision: "...when the last stone lights, we move. Confirm at the convergence." Silence. Nin watches the party. UNLOCK: CORRECTLY INTERPRET BOTH FRAGMENTS — NO CHECK IF PLAYERS REASON IT ALOUD What the sounds mean: Reckoning has pre-positioned an advance unit near the Ashring. They are not stopping the ritual before it starts — they are waiting for the moment the last stone activates, when the Dawnborn are committed
and mid-ritual, to move. DC 13 Intelligence or Insight if players want a mechanical assist. When players name it correctly: Nin says "Yes" — in the exact voice of someone the party has spoken to today, whichever NPC felt most trustworthy. They can't do better than that, but they mean it. "Two weeks. Couldn't tell anyone. Didn't know how." — in a voice the party doesn't recognize. Something old. Cube from the left pocket. Wrong interpretation or dismissal: Nin plays Fragment 2 again. Louder. If players still don't engage: Nin pockets the cube and looks back at the east road. Window is closing. If players wait more than two scenes: Nin takes a step east. Still reachable, but closer to gone.

SCENE — CUBE 5 Orya Doss
Location: center dais, Ashring plaza | Type: The Logistics Problem

Sight: The Ashring empty at this hour. Stone circle, the center dais raised 5ft. Orya crouched at the south face of the dais with chalk and a small hammer, measuring a crack in the stone base. Her coat has been on that cold ground since the fourth bell. Sound: The tap of her hammer. Chalk scraping. The plaza quiet before the crowds arrive. Smell: Cold stone, chalk dust, early morning air. Touch: The flagstones are uneven and cold. The dais stone is dense, old, solid — except for the crack. Air: Dawn

chill still in the plaza. Sun not yet over the eastern roofline. WANT A specific plan for protecting the dais before she hands over her cube FEAR The ritual failing because no one did the practical thinking LIE None. Remarkably direct. Physical: dwarf, late thirties by dwarf reckoning, compact and completely still — the composure is real, not performed. Hair braided back, no adornment. Stone dust on her coat and knees from where she has been crouching at the dais base since the fourth bell. She watches approaching people the way a mason watches a wall: looking for what is wrong before anything else. She is already there, crouched at the base of the center dais with a small hammer and a piece of chalk. She has been here since the fourth bell. She stands when she sees the box. "Good. I need to show you something before we talk about the cube." She leads them to the south face of the dais stone. A hairline crack runs along the base, three hand-spans wide. Old impact damage, worsening with the seasons. "I've been measuring it for two months. The dais will hold through a normal ritual. It won't hold through a fight. If this stone takes significant damage before the activation word is spoken, whoever speaks it will need exceptional focus to
compensate — more than most people have under combat conditions." She looks at them. "Do you have a plan for protecting it? Or will you have one before the ritual starts?" This is not philosophical. She wants a specific answer: who protects the dais, how, and what's the contingency if that person goes down. UNLOCK: GIVE A REAL PLAN, OR COMMIT TO MAKING ONE AND ASK HER WHAT SHE KNOWS

If players ask for her numbers: "Seventy-five points of structural damage before it becomes a problem. After that, the ritual still works — but the speaker needs to hold focus under conditions that will be trying. Plan for that." Any genuine engagement with the logistics — a named person, a formation, a question about what "exceptional focus" means mechanically — satisfies her. "Good. I've been the only person thinking about this for two months." Cube. She places it in the box herself and looks back at the dais once. "Cormac was at the Dawnhall two hours ago. Still sitting. Get there before Ysel runs out of patience — she's had more than anyone should be asked to have." Dismissal or "we'll figure it out": "You'll figure it out." She sits back down at the dais base. "Come back when you have." She'll be here. She's been here since the fourth bell. Orya is the logistics person. She has been doing the preparation work nobody else thought about. The dais crack information matters in Session 5: 75 HP threshold, DC 18 Arcana if breached. She is the only Dawnborn who found this. Let that register.

SCENE — HARDEST Cormac Drell Location: Alley behind the Dawnhall | Type: The Confession WANT To not have to look at his own yes FEAR That when he looks, he will find it was never courage LIE "I stand by what I said." — he isn't sure there was ever a self behind that yes. Physical: mid-thirties, dockworker-broad, the kind of man who used to fill a room. Now looks like that same person with something taken out of the center. Dark circles. Restless hands — picking at the clay mug, setting it down, picking it up. Does not make eye

contact easily. When he does, holds it longer than intended. Sight: Narrow alley behind the Dawnhall. Damp brick. A crate someone left against the wall that Cormac is using as a seat. Grey sky overhead. He has been here long enough that the morning light has moved. Sound: Kitchen noise from inside — muffled, domestic. Someone chopping. The alley is otherwise quiet. Smell: Damp stone, kitchen smoke, the canal two blocks east. Touch: The alley ground is wet. The brick wall he is leaning against has not dried from last night. Air: Cold. Stale between the buildings. He has not moved in a while. He is sitting on a crate with his back against the wall, clay mug in both hands, eyes on the middle distance. He hears the party arrive. Does not look up immediately. "I knew someone would come. Didn't know when." He looks at the puzzle box. "I know what that is. I know why you're here." He does not stand. Does not reach for the cube. He is waiting to see what they do next. Two-beat challenge. Both required. Beat 1 — the right question. The wrong question is "will you still do it?" He will say yes automatically and mean nothing. The right question is why he said yes in the first place. Any version of that question works. He needs to be asked to

look at the original decision, not just confirm the current one. When asked why: "I said yes when I thought it would be over before I had time to think about it again. It kept not being over." Then, if a player stays without pushing: "Do you want the part I can't say out loud anywhere else? A man can want to save his city, or he can want to be done with his own life — and from the inside those two things feel exactly the same. I said yes nine weeks ago and I still don't know which one it was." Beat 2 — do not fix it. He does not need to be told he is brave. He does not need reassurance. He needs someone to sit with the possibility that he wasn't, and stay anyway. If a player tries to argue him out of his doubt, he closes off: "I need you to stop asking me that." UNLOCK: BOTH BEATS COMPLETE — RIGHT QUESTION ASKED, UGLY ANSWER HEARD WITHOUT FIXING After the silence: "Because I told people I would. And they've been patient with me. That's not a good reason. It's the only one I've got that's true." He stands. Takes the cube from his coat. Does not hand it over — sets it on the crate between them. Flag: CORMAC RENEWED. He chose it again. The difference between the first yes and this one is that this one was looked at. If players only ask beat 1 but fix the answer: he says yes and means nothing. Cube technically given. RENEWED flag not set — his stone lights but costs something in Session 5. If players skip to "will you still do it?": "Yes." Flat. He gives the cube without eye contact. RENEWED flag not set. RENEWED flag is the difference between Ending A (sacrifice required) and Ending B (all survive). A Cormac who examined his consent and chose again is the ritual's tenth willing participant. A Cormac who just said yes again is a body at a stone.

SCENE — CUBE 6 (SESSION 4 VISIT / CUBE GIVEN HERE IF PLAYERS HELP) Lira Anwick — Healing House

Location: Lowmark Healing House ward | Type: The Trolley WANT Someone to help her make an impossible call FEAR That she will make the wrong choice alone and have to live with it LIE "I'm fine." — she has been standing in the middle of the ward holding a vial for twenty minutes. Physical: lizardfolk, amber-scaled, copper-dark at the hands from years of tincture work. Apron stained with medicine residue. She does not stop moving when she talks — except right now she has stopped moving entirely, which is the tell. Voice flat and precise — she learned human bedside manner as a second language and it shows when she is under pressure. The calculation is not her problem. She has known the optimal answer for twenty minutes. The problem is she has also practiced human medicine for twenty- two years and she no longer trusts purely optimal answers. Sight: Three occupied sickbeds. Lira standing motionless in the center of the ward, a small sealed vial in both hands. She has been standing there long enough that one patient has stopped watching her. Sound: Labored breathing from the far bed. The pestle she was using still on the grinding table, abandoned. Smell: Crushed menthol, boiled bandages, tincture residue on her hands. Touch: The ward floor is worn smooth from years of foot traffic between the beds. Air: Warm, sterile, still. The kind

of quiet that settles in when someone has been not-deciding for a long time. She hears them enter. Does not turn immediately. "You're here for the cube. I know. I need ten minutes first, and I need you to help me." She holds up the vial. "One dose of stabilizing tincture. Three patients who need it. One hour before the window closes. I've been standing here for twenty minutes and I cannot decide." The three patients: Mireille, 19. Grey sickness, early stage. Best recovery odds of the three. No one has visited her in two weeks. She hasn't complained about this. Oshen, 52. Guild organizer — spent twenty years arranging emergency food and medicine for Lowmark families during bad winters. Has also, Lira knows, been quietly cruel to his own family for most of that time. Moderate odds. Elder Varn, 71. Lira's mentor. Taught her to read, to compound medicine, to sit with a dying person without flinching. Low odds even with treatment — this buys time, not survival. She has not asked for anything. "There is no fourth option. I checked three days ago when the supply route closed. I've been rationing since then hoping more would arrive. It didn't."

"I am not asking you to make the call for me. I am asking you to help me think about it so I don't have to carry the thinking alone." UNLOCK: ENGAGE SERIOUSLY — ANY FRAMEWORK, ANY ANSWER, OWNED

Players can argue for any of the three. They can argue from expected outcome (Mireille), social utility (Oshen), loyalty (Varn), or patient autonomy (ask Varn what she wants — she will say "give it to the young one, I've had my time"). No answer is wrong if it is argued and owned. What fails: deflecting, leaving the decision entirely to Lira, or refusing to engage. When the party commits to an answer: Lira is quiet for a moment. Then she moves to the chosen patient's bed and administers the dose. Does not second-guess. Does not thank them. "I've been practicing medicine for twenty-two years. I've made decisions like this alone before. I'll make them alone again. But not today. Thank you." Cube. "I'll be at the Ashring at dawn. I'll have arranged for someone to stay." Refuse to engage, try to rush her, or leave: "I've been asking for help for twenty minutes. You're not it. Come back another day." No cube. She makes the call herself. The party lost her trust, not her cube — she'll still come to the ritual. But she won't forget. If players ask Varn herself — she says: "Give it to the young one. I've had my time." This is its own moment. Let it land before anyone speaks. Lira does not cry. She goes very still.

FLOATING ENCOUNTER — SCENE 3B The Flowering Approach — Ixa
Triggers between any two cube scenes, or forced at end of Cormac scene if Ixa ignored the letter | Private: letter arrives for Ixa specifically | Ellan/Ixa recognition already played — Ellan in safe house Sight: A pressed flower in a doorway crack. One petal too many. Center darker than it should be. Sound: Nothing. The lane is empty. Someone was here a moment ago. Smell: Faintly botanical. Not unpleasant. Not right. Touch: The letter paper is
slightly warm — not from the sun. From being held. Air: The sensation of being watched from a direction that has no one in it. The letter is addressed to "the one who should not exist, but does."
"We helped someone once. A woman in this city, many years ago, who loved someone the world said she was not permitted to love. We showed her it was possible. You are the outcome."
"We have been trying to make more outcomes like you. We have not always succeeded. The ones who did not succeed are still with us."

"Come to us. Or simply stop walking away. We will find each other." This is for Ixa's player. Whether she shares the letter with the party is her choice. If Ixa ignores the letter or the party moves to shut down the approach: The Flowering sends retrieval. Two Grasping Tendrils arrive. They are not violent in intent. They are extremely violent in body. SECONDARY OBJECTIVE — STATE BEFORE COMBAT Prevent Ixa from being carried off. The Tendrils grapple Ixa exclusively. If one gets Ixa grappled for 2+ rounds, a third Tendril emerges from a side alley to assist escape. Protecting Ixa matters more than defeating the creatures. Grasping Tendril — quick stats (full block in encounter reference) AC 14 | HP 91 | Speed 35 Resist: nonmagical B/P/S | Immune: charmed, frightened Grasping Slam +7 | 2d6+4, grapple escape DC 16 Constrict (vs grappled): 2d8+4, DC 15 Str or restrained Haul (BA): full move dragging grappled target Target Lock: cannot be taunted off Ixa At 0 HP: down but conscious. Still reaching for Ixa. Not dead. Eyes open. One wears a plain iron ring. One has a child's name tattooed on the inner forearm, cut through by whatever happened to the skin around it. DC 12 Medicine: this is a person. Altered down to the bone. Still in there behind the eyes. Knows what was done to it. Cannot say. After combat, a second pressed flower is tucked in the larger Tendril's clothing: "We will try again. We always do. Please just stop walking away." The party must decide what to do with the downed Tendrils. There is no clean answer. If Ixa says she will go willingly: both Tendrils stop immediately and stand aside. Ixa going with the Flowering is a live Session 5 track. Do not resolve here.